At that stage, however, the US had not wanted to provide more than a nonspecific assurance.[203] In the aftermath of the test, Johnson had given a speech indicating American support for countries subjected to nuclear coercion or attack. The joint chiefs and the secretary of defense had agreed that the US should give "general assurances" to those threatened by the Chinese, but they had asserted that any specific talks with India should keep in mind the goal of not alienating Pakistan.[204] A more overarching concern had been that any specific assurance would tie US hands.

India had a dilemma on this front. On the one hand, the assurance in Johnson's speech had been too implicit to be considered reliable. The Indian ambassador had said he was skeptical of the reliability of such an informal assurance, especially in the absence of a formal US-India tie. He believed that "the United States would not come to [India's] aid by attacking China if at the same time the Soviet Union said that it would assist China under such an attack."[205] On the other hand, however, India had little desire to pursue an explicit assurance that would require it to make a binding commitment to the US. Shastri had made clear that India would not join a military alliance.[206]

This did not, however, mean that India had not wanted any assurance. Shastri had told British prime minister Harold Wilson to inform the Johnson administration that the only alternative to an Indian nuclear program was an umbrella supplied by the nuclear powers, including the Soviet Union.[207] Publicly, as well, he had urged the nuclear powers to find a way to assure nonnuclear nations about their security against a nuclear attack.[208] He had reiterated in spring 1965 that the superpowers, at least, should guarantee the safety of nonnuclear states. Privately, he had not asked for an assurance just for India, asserting that it would be "unwise."[209] A broader guarantee would mean India would not appear to have joined an alliance. A joint guarantee, in turn, would not require India to tilt, would not provoke the Soviet Union or drive it back toward China, and, furthermore, would be a hedge against the uncertain reliability of one guarantor.

Meanwhile, the US had received reports that the Indian cabinet had given Bhabha the go-ahead for the first stage of producing a nuclear weapon and would review the situation after a year. US officials had worried that India had been leaking such information in order to elicit a guarantee from the US. However, the foreign minister at the time, Swaran